

7, The Qing Rulers' Astute Distinction Between Two Types of Bureaucrats

Recently (*referring to mid-2023*), the classic 1999 historical drama *Yongzheng Dynasty* (《雍正王朝》) caught fire again on internet platforms, though its popularity as a classic has never really waned. While swiping through various spoof videos adapted from *Yongzheng Dynasty*, I began to notice an issue I had known about before but had not given much attention to: the distinction between the appellations of "**Minister**" (臣 / **Chen**) and "**Slave**" (奴才 / **Nucai**) during the Manchu rule over China.

The popular explanation is that Han Chinese officials generally referred to themselves as "Ministers," whereas officials within the Eight Banners (八旗) system referred to themselves as "Slaves." Of course, this is a very generalized and imprecise explanation. For example, when Manchu and Han officials jointly submitted a memorial to the throne, all co-signers had to refer to themselves as "Ministers," because a joint memorial did not represent a private viewpoint.

I have no intention here to meticulously dissect the exact rules governing the application of these two appellations, let alone the inevitable exceptions that broke these rules in actual history.

What truly caught my attention is that this distinction in titles was not merely used to determine the degree of intimacy with the emperor; more importantly, **it indicated a division of labor within the Qing Dynasty's ruling structure.**

I believe this was based on the Qing rulers' observation of Ming Dynasty history. Because one can easily note that for over half a century—from Nurhaci's initial uprising until the complete annihilation of the remnant Southern Ming forces—the Manchu monarchs essentially witnessed the entire process of the Ming Dynasty from its decline to its ultimate collapse.

For monarchs pursuing absolute autocracy, the history of the Ming Dynasty obviously forced them to ponder a question: *Since the Ming monarchs theoretically never lost their power, and the autocracy of the Ming Empire was stronger than any previous period in China, why was it that during the reigns of the final few Ming monarchs, the decisions of an emperor with theoretically unchecked power were so difficult to execute?*

What the Qing rulers saw was this: although the Ming bureaucratic system could ensure the emperor completely divided the **landlord class**—preventing them from forming a unified class consciousness, let alone achieving an alliance—the **entire bureaucratic system could indeed adopt a collective posture of "non-violent non-cooperation"** (非暴力不合作). On the surface, they would be infinitely submissive to the emperor; but in reality, these bureaucrats neither possessed the capability, nor could they possibly harbor any positive attitude toward thankless, arduous tasks.

Where the Qing monarchs were truly brilliant was that, despite being **barbarians** who conquered the Central Plains, they clearly discerned that under an autocratic monarchy, there existed two distinctly different types of bureaucrats within the bureaucratic system.

The first type consists of the general administrative bureaucrats. Their function is to assist the monarch in governing. This is the inevitable result of the finite energy and capability of any single individual.

The second type belongs to a special class of dedicated bureaucrats whose sole function is to **"exceptionally maintain"** or **"exceptionally funnel"** interests (*the personal interests of the rulers, of course*). For the former ("maintaining"), one easily thinks of espionage and military security; for

the latter ("funneling"), one easily thinks of affairs like grain transport (漕运), salt administration (盐运), and imperial textile manufacturing (织造). *(The connotations here are very rich, including managing imperial estates [皇庄] and minting currency, but I will only list examples relatively unique to China).*

(Of course, if we expand our observation of the bureaucratic system, we will find that there is actually a third category of people: the "clerks/functionaries" [吏 / Li] responsible for execution at the grassroots level of society. Regarding the role played by the "Li" and the distinction between them and the "officials" [官 / Guan], some scholars in our country have already discussed this quite sufficiently in private, so I will not elaborate further here).

This distinction implies that to maintain bureaucratic rule, one cannot blindly rely solely on **rotating officials** (流官 / Liuguan).

If we view the emperor ruling the state as the master of a massive manor (大庄园主), then the bureaucrats wielding general administrative power can be seen as the **"managers"** (管家) responsible for estate management. Meanwhile, those officials exceptionally capable of protecting the master's interests or helping the master extract wealth can be viewed as the **"domestic slaves/servants"** (仆役) of the manor.

If we imagine ourselves as the master of a manor, how would we prefer to acquire our domestic slaves? Would we run to a slave market to buy slaves gathered from all corners of the earth whose backgrounds are entirely unknown to us? Or would we lean towards employing the descendants of servants who have already worked in the manor for generations?

The answer is overwhelmingly obvious. Under rational calculation, making the second choice is inevitable! **Because we know the latter's backgrounds inside out, making them far more trustworthy; and their vulnerabilities (软肋) are easily grasped, making them far simpler to control.**

This choice is highly rational for the rulers. Only when it is absolutely necessary to rebalance power, or when there is a genuine shortage of manpower, does recruiting new servants become pressing.

Therefore, we can conclude: **The "managers" of the manor must absolutely not be hereditary.** If the managers also become hereditary, the master's power will be divided. **However, for the "domestic slaves," the absolute first choice is the old retainers of the household.** For this category of roles, capability is not the primary factor to be considered; absolute loyalty and ease of control are paramount!

As the Manchus replaced the Ming Empire in ruling over China, they realized that the Ming Dynasty had not institutionalized the distinction between the roles of "managers" and "servants."

For every generation of Ming emperors, his high-level "servants" at the dynastic level—whether the Eunuch Director of Ceremonial (司礼监掌印太监) or the Commander of the Jinyiwei (Embroidered Uniform Guard / 锦衣卫指挥使)—could at best only be considered old retainers from his days as a prince (潜邸中的老人). They failed to form a cross-generational community of shared interests.

Each generation of emperors had to expend time and energy rebuilding the servant system for the grand manor of the empire. Meanwhile, for the "imperial managers" in the imperial court, it was

entirely possible to form interest groups spanning two or three generations through patronage in the imperial examinations and political marriages. Consequently, the autocratic monarch's capacity to impose his will was significantly compromised.

This phenomenon caused numerous political catastrophes in the late Ming, which clearly left a profound impression on the Manchu rulers of the time.

Thus, we can understand the drastic transformation in the essence of the "Eight Banners System" (八旗制度) as the Qing began its rule over China. When the Eight Banners system initially formed during Nurhaci's reign, its primary purpose was clearly not to maintain a massive bureaucratic system ruling over China; it was highly questionable whether Nurhaci even realized his descendants could conquer China.

However, during the process of the Manchu government consolidating its rule over China, cunning politicians like Hong Taiji, Dorgon, and Fulin quickly realized that the Eight Banners—originally a **military aristocracy** (军事贵族) group prioritizing military objectives—was exceptionally well-suited to play the role of "servant bureaucrats" within the overall bureaucratic system!

This practice ultimately endowed the Eight Banners system with new significance. Through the Eight Banners, the Qing Dynasty transformed bureaucratic China's original "Monarch-Minister structure" (君—臣结构) into a **"Monarch-Minister, Master-Slave dual structure"** (君—臣, 主—奴二元结构).

The Eight Banners established the rules for hereditary succession among the "slaves," forming a system capable of operating normally across multiple generations. It was highly differentiated in function, with its paramount duty being to maintain and extract interests for the Manchu emperor. As for the vast majority of administrative posts, they naturally still belonged to Han Chinese officials who were not bannermen.

Judging by the results, this institutional design was extremely effective. One can clearly sense the difference between the Qing and Ming dynasties from both internal and external perspectives: namely, their tax-collecting capacity and expansionist capability. (*Of course, as we will point out later, another entirely unignorable reason is the strengthening of Western influence; the emergence of modern elements enabled the **infrastructural power** [基础性权力] of the Chinese Empire to expand.*)

Today, although the Qing Dynasty has become history, the conceptual design of the Eight Banners has by no means vanished!

For people living in the Soviet Union and countries established according to its model, it is hard not to feel that Lenin's so-called "vanguard party" (先锋队政党) is nothing more than the manifestation of the Eight Banners in modern society. The Chinese saying, **"The Eight Banners are gone, leaving only the Plain Red Banner"** (八旗惟余正红旗), is absolutely no empty talk!

Therefore, when people observe the phenomenon of families acquiring positions across generations in China's state-owned enterprises, there is genuinely no need to be surprised. Because the hereditary rights of the Eight Banners were never acquired stealthily; they were exactly what the Great Qing Emperors permitted and intentionally promoted!

Embezzlement and bribery are even more well within the bounds permitted by unspoken rules (潜规则). It even constitutes a behavior of intentionally handing over one's vulnerabilities (把柄) to demonstrate loyalty! The rulers will indeed push out a scapegoat to be executed when necessary.

Ever since the Qing Dynasty, the rulers of the **restoration-bureaucratic states** have been acutely aware of one principle: **While they eat the meat, leaving some soup for their slaves to drink will not cause them any real loss. Only a "thief" breaking into the house constitutes an apocalyptic disaster.**

It is just that because many regions of the world have already embraced modern civilization, these explicit rules (明规则) of the empire had to be converted into unspoken rules. Consequently, the universally ignorant Chinese commoners understand this less and less, appearing even easier to deceive than the people of the Qing Dynasty!

Another thought-provoking and rather laughable matter is that the rulers of the Soviet Union and Soviet-style states were vastly more foolish than the Manchu emperors. They lacked even the basic concept of how to utilize the "Plain Red Banner"—the vanguard party.

The formidable power of the Eight Banners lay in functional specialization: the servants only did what servants were supposed to do, rather than usurping the work of the managers.

Yet, when ruling their countries, these Bolsheviks completely failed to notice this. They merely attempted to blindly hoard power. Before long, they trapped themselves in a situation where **"the Party commands everything"** (党指挥一切) and there was no separation between the Party and the State (党政不分). Little did they know, this actually weakened their own rule. Both the sheer malice and the supreme stupidity of these rulers are fully encapsulated right here.

(Of course, people might point out a certain inevitability in Vanguard states undergoing this transformation. After all, no matter how autocratic or bureaucratic these states are, they lack a hereditary royal family—unless it's a situation like North Korea. Without an emperor, whose servants are the "Eight Banners" supposed to be? Under conditions of unconstrained absolute power, it is almost inevitable for an organization to continually expand its own jurisdiction).

As of writing this, I have not yet made a clear distinction between **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) and **despotic power** (专制性权力). In reality, the Qing rulers' differentiation between the two types of bureaucrats perfectly conformed to the objective laws governing the different operational logics of these two powers. This represents yet another milestone in the consolidation of China's **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度). Readers will naturally understand this when they read Sections 15, 16, and 30 of Chapter XII.

Finally, people might ask this question: *Was the Qing Dynasty's introduction of the Eight Banners system into China a historical progression or a historical regression?*

I find this question exceptionally fascinating. Setting aside administrative and military capacities (*which are irrelevant to historical progression*), the Qing Dynasty, having introduced the Eight Banners system, did indeed exhibit more **"feudalization"** factors than the Ming Dynasty—this holds true for both the Bannermen and the Han Chinese **landlord class**. Going from the pure **restoration-bureaucratic society** of the Ming Dynasty to recovering certain feudal elements... from this angle, it seems like a slight progression.

But on the other hand, it is glaringly obvious that the Eight Banners were light-years away from true **feudal nobility**. It was a system heavily emphasizing personal dependency relations, thus exhibiting characteristics of a **slavery society** (奴隶制社会), which is obviously far more backward than a **feudal society**.

Not to mention that this system ultimately existed merely to strengthen the emperor's personal autocracy; it was the *result* of the development of the **restoration-bureaucratic system**, not a process of its disintegration!

Ultimately, ever since the Tang and Song dynasties, the evaluation criteria of "progression" or "regression" have become completely unsuitable for evaluating Chinese society.

Because evaluating progression or regression requires a coordinate system. Just like the track in a long-distance race: moving toward the finish line is progression, and moving away from it is regression. But the situation of Chinese society is that **the contestant has completely veered off the track entirely**, existing in some utterly indeterminate void!

Therefore, this kind of society can only be described as "**aberrant**" (变态的 / **pathological**). At most, you can evaluate whether it has become *more* "aberrant," but you cannot determine whether it has progressed or regressed a little.

Evaluating whether changes constitute historical progression or historical reaction has lost all meaning under the extreme social conditions of our country.

This society died a thousand years ago, and a dead man is neither healthy nor sick.

Even if there is anything left worth saving here, it is the *people* living on this land—absolutely not the so-called "**Chinese civilization**" (中华文明), which has long since become antithetical to human civilization itself!

7, 清朝统治者对于两种官僚高明的区分

最近（指23年中）1999年拍摄的老剧《雍正王朝》在互联网平台上又火了，虽然作为经典老剧它的热度从来也不低。在刷到各种改编于《雍正王朝》的恶搞视频的同时，我也开始注意到一个以前虽然知道但是并没有给予太多关注的问题，那就是在满洲人统治中国时“臣”和“奴才”两种称谓之间的区别。通俗的说法是汉臣一般自称为“臣”，而八旗体制内的大臣自称为“奴才”，当然这是一种非常概括的不确切的说法，例如当满汉大臣联合上奏的时候联名的人全部都要自称为“臣”，因为联名的奏折不代表一种私人观点。我无意在此去细致地区分两种称呼在应用时到底有什么规则，更不要提在实际的历史中突破规则的例外，总是免不了。真正让我非常在意的事情是，这种称呼之别不仅仅是用来确定亲疏关系，更表明了满清统治结构中的一种分工。我认为这是基于一种清代统治者对于明朝历史的观察，因为人们很容易注意到从努尔哈赤起兵开始直到残余的南明势力被完全剿灭为止大半个世纪间，满洲的君主事实上完整见证了明朝从衰落到覆灭的整个过程。对于追求进行专制统治的君主来说，明朝的历史显然让他们思考一个问题，既然明代的君主在事实上从来没有失去权力，明帝国的专制主义要强过此前中国的任何一个时期，那么为什么在明代晚期最后几个君主统治时，即使理论上权力不受遏制的皇帝其决策也难以被执行呢？清朝统治者所看到的是，尽管明代的官僚体制已经能够确保皇帝将地主阶级完全分化，使之不能形成统一的阶级意识更遑论达成联合，但是整个官僚体制确实能够采取一种“非暴力不合作”的共同姿态，在表面上对皇帝无比恭顺，在事实上官僚既没有能力，对于吃力不讨好的事更不可能抱有积极的态度。

清朝君主真正聪明的地方在于，尽管他们是入主中原的蛮族，但是却清晰地看出在专制君主制下的官僚体制中存在两种官僚。第一种就是一般意义上负责行政的官僚，它们的作用是协助君主进行统治，这是任何个人精力、能力有限的必然结果。而第二种官僚属于特殊的专职官僚，其作用即“特别能维护”或者“特别能输送”利益（当然是统治者个人的），对前者人们很容易想到漕运、盐运和织造等事

务（这里内涵非常丰富，包括打理皇庄，负责铸币，我只列举在中国比较特别的例子），后者则显然包括特务和军事保卫。（当然如果我们扩大对官僚系统的观察就会发现实际上还有第三类人，那就是在社会基层负责执行的“吏”。关于“吏”扮演的角色和其与“官”之间的区别，我国的一些学者在私下里讨论得已经较为充分，所以在这里我也不再多说）这种区别意味着，要想维护官僚统治不可能一味地指望流官。

如果我们把统治国家的皇帝视为一个大庄园主，那么一般掌握行政权力的官僚可以看作是负责庄园管理的管家。而那些特别能够保护主人利益或帮助主人攫取利益的官员则可以被视为庄园的仆役。如果我们假设自己是一个庄园主，我们会倾向于以何种方式获得仆役呢？是跑到牙行里购买那些天南地北汇聚到此的不知根底的奴隶，还是倾向于任用庄园中早已工作很久的仆役的后人？这个答案相当明显，在理性思考下进行第二种选择是必然的，因为我们对后者更加知根知底，因此他们更值得信任；他们的软肋很容易被拿捏，因此我们控制起来也更简单。这种选择对统治者来说是非常合理的，只有在有必要重新平衡力量，或者人手确实不足的时候吸纳新的仆役才显得紧要。因此我们可以说，庄园的管家是不可以世袭的，如果管家也变得世袭罔替，那么主人的权利就会被分割；而奴仆则首选宅邸的旧人，对于这一类角色而言能力并非首要被考虑的因素，忠心和方便控制是最重要的。

当满洲人取代明帝国对中国进行统治的过程中，他们意识到明朝并没有将管家和仆人两种角色进行制度化的区分。对于每一代明朝的皇帝来说，他这一朝级的高级别“仆役”，无论是司礼监掌印太监还是锦衣卫指挥使，充其量都只能算潜邸中的老人，没有形成跨越代际的利益共同体。每一代皇帝都需要花费时间和精力重建帝国这个大庄园的仆役体系，而对于朝堂上的“帝国管家”们而言，他们通过科场提携和联姻等方式形成跨越两代或三代人的利益团体是有可能的，专制君主贯彻自己意志的能力就受到了影响。这种现象在明末造成了诸多政治乱象，它显然给当时的满洲统治者留下了深刻的印象。这样我们就可以理解“八旗制度”的内涵在清朝开始统治中国的过程中所发生的巨变，当八旗制度最初在努尔哈赤统治时期形成的时候，他的最初目的显然不是为了维护一个统治中国的庞大官僚系统服务的，努尔哈赤能不能意识到自己的后人可以征服中国都是个问题。但是当满洲政府并巩固对中国的统治这一过程中，皇太极、多尔衮和福临这样狡猾的政治家很快意识到八旗这个最初以军事目的为先的军事贵族集团非常适合用来扮演官僚系统内的仆从官僚的角色。这种实践最终赋予了八旗制度新的意义，清朝通过八旗将官僚制中国原先的“君—臣结构”，变成“君—臣，主—奴二元结构”。八旗确定了奴才之间世代相继的规则，形成了能在几代人时间内正常运行的体制。它在职能上高度分化，以为满清皇帝维护和攫取利益为要务，至于绝大多数行政岗位当然还是属于非旗人的汉官。这种制度设计从结果来看极为有效，人们可以从内外两个方面明显感觉到清代与明代的差异，即征税能力和扩张能力。当然在更后面我们也会指出，另一个全然不可忽视的原因是西方影响的增强，现代因素的出现使得中华帝国的基础性权力得以扩张。

如今清朝虽然已经成为历史，但是八旗的构想却并没有消失，对于在苏联以及依照其模式建立起的国家生活的人而言很难不感受到列宁所谓的先锋队政党无非是八旗在现代社会的表现罢了，中国所谓的“八旗惟余正红旗”绝非虚言。因此当人们观察到中国的国有企业存在家族世代取得职务的情况实在不用感到惊讶，因为八旗的世袭权利根本就不是偷偷摸摸取得的，恰恰是大清皇帝允许和有意推进的。贪污受贿更是在潜规则允许的范围内，甚至属于一种有意上交把柄表忠心的行为，统治者在必要的时候确实会把替罪羊推出去杀掉。自从清朝以来复辟官僚国家的统治者十分清楚自己吃肉，留口汤给奴才喝是不会让他有什么损失的，只有家里遭的“贼”才是灭顶之灾。只不过因为世界很多地区已经接纳了现代文明，这种明规则就不得不转为潜规则，以至于普遍无知的中国老百姓越来越不了解罢了，比起清朝人都显得更加好骗。

还有一个思之令人发笑的事情是，苏联及苏联式国家的统治者远远比满洲皇帝更加愚蠢，他们甚至对于如何利用先锋队政党这个“正红旗”缺乏观念。八旗的威力在于职能的特化，仆役就只做仆役做的事，而不是把管家的工作也抢过来。而这些布尔什维克统治国家时根本注意不到这一点，只是试图一味攫取权利，用不了多久就陷入党指挥一切，党政不分的境地，殊不知这样恰恰会削弱自己的统治，统治者的坏和愚蠢都体现在这里了。（当然人们也会指出先锋队国家发生这种变化存在某种必然性，只是因为这些国家再专制也好，官僚也罢，毕竟不存在一个世袭统治的皇室，除非像朝鲜那种情况，八旗去给谁做仆役呢？在没有限制又拥有权力的情况下，一个组织继续扩大自己的权力几乎是必然的）

当我写到这里的时候还没有对于基础性权力和专制性权力进行明确的区分。实际上清代统治者对于两种官僚的区别完全合乎两种权力运行逻辑不同的客观规律，是中国复辟官僚制度稳固的又一个里程碑。读者在读到第十二章第十五、第十六节以及第三十节的时候自然就会明白。

最后，人们或许会问这样一个问题，清朝将八旗制度引入中国是一种历史的进步还是退步？我认为这个问题非常有意思，抛开与历史进步无关的行政能力和军事能力不谈，引入八旗制的清朝确实在一定程度上比明朝展现出了更多“封建化”的因素，无论是对八旗而言还是对于汉族地主而言都是如此。从明代那种纯粹的复辟官僚社会到恢复一定封建因素，站在这个角度似乎是有一些进步。但是另外一方面人们可以显然看出八旗离真正的封建贵族差得还有十万八千里，这是一种高度强调人身依附关系的制度，又具显然比封建社会要更为落后的奴隶制社会的特征。更不要说这种体制最终还是为了加强皇帝个人专制而存在，它属于复辟官僚制度发展的结果，而不是瓦解的过程。说到底，自唐宋以来进步或者落后这个评价标准已经完全不适合用来评价中国社会。因为进步还是落后需要一个坐标来加以确定，就好比一个长跑比赛的赛道一样，靠近终点的属于进步，而远离终点的自然属于落后。而中国社会的情况就属于参赛选手已经完全不在于赛道上了，而是处在某个根本无法确定位置的地方，因此这种社会应该说是“变态”的，你顶多评价它有没有变得更“变态”，而无法认为他到底是进步了一点，还是退后了一点。评价变化属于历史进步还是历史反动在我国这种极端的社会条件下已经失去了意义，这个社会在 1000 年前就已经死了，死人是无所谓健康还是生病的。就算说这里还有什么值得挽救的那也是生活在土地上的人民，而非早就与文明相悖的“中华文明”。